

“A suffocating fear lingers on”

It was an unremarkable Saturday. October 5, 12:15 pm. Richa Mishra, a journalist at India Today Television, picked a call from an unknown number. “This is Karan Verma from FedEx,” said the voice. “You’ve sent a courier.” Richa frowned. “I haven’t sent anything.” The voice answered, “There’s been a seizure at Mumbai airport. Suspicious items were found in your name.” Her stomach tightened. “What kind of items?”

“Five passports, three credit cards…and 200 grams of MDMA.” “MDMA?” her voice trembled. “Drugs, ma’am. Your Aadhaar card must have been misused.” As panic set in, Karan transferred her to Vinay Kumar Chaudhary “from the Mumbai Police”. “You are involved in drug smuggling and money-laundering. We have an arrest warrant in your name,” he said. “For two hours, they tormented me in my home.” The callers knew all: her schedule, her family, her fears. “No money was demanded, but every two hours, they demanded updates, keeping me in a constant state of dread.” When her tormentors hung up, she called up a relative and a senior colleague, who assured her it was a trap. Later, she filed a police complaint. What’s harrowing is “the suffocating fear that lingers on. A digital arrest…is like losing a piece of yourself”, she says. “Even when the trap is broken, the echoes haunt you, reminding you that the prison was never physical. It was built in your mind.”

-Pradip R. Sagar